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est one! And Android's edge is not restricted to cost alone. As the OS is open source, software developers can design applications for it easily and offer them to users for download. The Android Market is already emerging as a wonderful repository of software that runs on Android phones and a lot of it is free of cost. Users can download and install just about any software that they like from the Android Market.

Despite open source OS having been around for years now, the PC and mobile worlds are dominated by Windows and Symbian. Never has the open source OS banner been carried by someone as prominent as Google. The search engine giant's presence has added a glamour element that had been conspicuous by its absence in the open source movement. And speaking of movements, Android is the OS of choice for the open handset alliance, which has the likes of HTC, Samsung, Intel, Qualcomm and Motorola among its members. As Goel predicts, there will be several more Android handsets in the Indian market by the year end.

The magic of Android

Speaking of handsets brings us to the one that has started all the chatter of Android in India—HTC Magic. As a piece of hardware, it is a sleek looking plastic body with decent technical specifications (3.2-megapixel camera, 8.1cm touchscreen, GPS, Wi-Fi) but it is when you switch it on that the power of Android hits you full in the face. The home screen of the device is spread over three screens which you can access by flicking your finger to the right or left. This home screen is totally in your control—you can place applications and widgets wherever you want on it (there is no invisible grid that insists that applications have to be placed in a straight line). That apart, the software on the phone has just about everything a smartphone user could want—an excellent Internet browser, an e-mail client that supports MS exchange server and the option to search for content on the phone and

the Internet. There is even a dedicated search button below the touchscreen! The phone works at a blinding speed with hardly any lag time, even when you have several applications open, and serves up a decent battery life.

Absence of applications

Unfortunately, the OS of the device has some limitations. A closer look reveals the absence of some Google applications such as the e-mail client, the chat facility, Google Maps and, to top it all, the much talked-about Android Market. The reason for this is the fact that the version of Android running on the HTC Magic is different from the one made by Google—as the OS is open source, HTC has made some changes to it. As of now, these changes tend to cripple the device as one has no maps to make use of its GPS facility and cannot download applications for it. While HTC insists that access to Android Market will be provided in the coming days through a software patch, Android supporters have been disappointed at the exclusion of what many feel is the 'killer app' of the OS on its India debut.

Not as disappointed, though, as they were by the price. At Rs 29,900, the HTC Magic is very much on the higher side and in the same league as phones with better specifications, such as Nokia's E75, BlackBerry Storm, HTC Diamond 2 and even the iPhone 3G. Many consumers feel that the device is grossly overpriced considering the fact that it runs on an open source OS and has technical specifications that are well below those of other phones selling in the same price bracket.

All of this has left many users disappointed with Android's debut in India. However, it would be premature to write off the OS on the basis of a single phone. The HTC Magic might not be able to cast a spell on the Indian consumer but it is a fair chance that Android will, before the year is out. ●

The author is a freelance writer with a passion for mobile phones